THE JICAQUES OF HONDURAS

By Edward Conzemius

The Indians called Jicaques (Xicaques, Hicaques) by the Spanish-speaking inhabitants of Honduras and "Tol" or "Tor" by themselves, are spread over a large part of Central Honduras. They number from 1200 to 1500 and are divided into two tribes speaking two very closely related languages.

The western tribe lives in the vicinity of the pueblos Chamelecon and Villanueva, Department of Cortés. It is near extinction, not exceeding a population of 100.

The Eastern tribe numbers over 1000 people and is distributed in the following departments:

Tegucigalpa : Vicinity of Marales and Orica.
Yoro : » » Yoro, Olanchito, Yorito Morazan and El Negrito.
Atlantida : Vicinity of Tela.

The Jicaques are not mentioned at all in the reports of the conquistadores. The historian Domingo Juarros and in later years Archbishop F. García Peláez gave us some vague accounts of this group of Indians. The former seems to have been of the opinion that the Lencas and Jicaques are very closely related, while the latter writer states that the Payas are also known by the name Jicaques. These two authors also state that the above named Indians used to conduct periodical raids on the Spanish settlements of Olancho. Squier does not shed much light on the subject neither, having apparently gained his information from the two above named authors, whose statements led him to the erroneous belief that the Jicaques, Lencas and Payas are of the same stock.

Alberto Membreño gives a vocabulary of the language in the second edition oh his "Hondureñismos", published in 1897 ; a short text precedes it but from the statements therein it is evident that the author had never visited the villages of the Indians [1].

The Jicaques were converted to Christianity by the Spanish missionary Manuel de Subirana who arrived in Yoro in 1860 and remained among them until his death which occurred in 1864. He persuaded the Indians to form large settlements, which were finally built with the cooperation of the Government. Upon his advise a ladino (meztizo) administrator, locally called "curador" was placed in charge of an Indian village, and only through this headman could any trading or other business with the outside world be transacted. The object of this was to save the ignorant Indian from being exploited by unscrupulous merchants but this scheme was an absolute failure. The curadores became little autocrats in their respective villages and oppressed the Indians, compelling them to give them their labor and products for an insignificant pay. The curadores were finally recalled, and the Indians, left alone, abandoned the towns and again erected their huts on the hills far away from the ladino settlements. Since then several attempts have been made to compel the Jicaques to form lar-

1. See also vocabularies by F. Guardia and J. F. Ferraz, Carlos Torres, Karl Sapper in Walter Lehmann, Zentral Amerika I, Pt. 2, pp. 631-635, 654 et seq.

ger settlements and establish schools, but so far without success.

The Jicaques are of bronze complexion and short stature. They are strong and enduring and are able to carry heavy loads for long distances on the back.

They are dying off rapidly; large families are seldom met with on account of the high infant mortality. In 1919 many fell victim to Spanish influenza. They suffer much from catarrh which is often fatal, and in past years they would not admit in their houses anybody suffering from catarrh. Many are inflicted by a skin disease, called locally "cativí", which is also common among the Indians of the Mosquito Coast.

They are very fond of "guaro" (rum) and the larger part of their earnings is spent for this intoxicating drink, which they obtain in the "estancos" in the villages of the ladinos.

Smoking is a universal habit among the men, while many of the women also use tobacco; the Indians, however, generally smoke the pipe, while the ladinos use nearly exclusively cigarettes.

They adhere to the Roman Catholic religion but have retained many superstitious beliefs. As among the ladinos of the lower class, few couples are legally married. Polygamy seems to be unknown among them.

Evil spirits are expelled by smoke; in olden times anything received from strangers was purified by hanging over the smoke, be it tobacco, food stuffs, money, etc.

A great influence among the Indians is exerted by the "tapuyero" or diviner. His tools consist of the "tapua", a bunch of small cords made from the maguey plant. I was unable to see any of these cords and only a few very old tapuyeros are still alive. By tying and untying knots in the tapúa while holding it towards different directions, the diviner is supposed to locate objects which have disappeared. In the department of Yoro the efficiency of the tapúa is believed in by the better educated Ladinos who often pay a tapuyero a few dollars in order to find out the whereabouts of lost live stock.

The Jicaques nowadays dress like the mestizos. Up to a dozen years ago, the women used to make clothing from the bark of the "matapalo" (a species of fig tree). For this purpose the tree was felled, the inner bark extracted, and rendered soft by leaving it in water for a few days. Afterwards it was stretched out by the action of the hardwood bark beater, receiving a light brownish color. A waistcloth or breechclout of this material was tied around the loins by the men. It is long and narrow; the ends are left to hang down, one in front and the other behind. A sleeveless shirt also of this bark completed the dress of the men. Sometimes this shirt was made of cotton and embroidered with feathers, but the spinning and weaving of cotton is now unknown to them. The dress of the women consisted of a shirt longer than that of the men but of the same shape and material.

Their huts usually consist of only one apartment. The walls are made of sticks of wood, sometimes of mud, while the roof is thatched with dried grass or palm leaves. The hard ground serves as floor; windows and chimneys are never seen. The fire is generally put on the floor in the center of the house; for cooking purposes they use earthen "ollas", but occasionally an iron kettle, brought from the Atlantic Coast, may be seen. The beds are made of sticks, raised about 3 feet from the ground; they also take the place of chairs and benches. Hammocks are not seen and as these Indians call them by the Spanish name, it is probable that they were not known to them originally. One will generally find in every house a metate to grind the corn, several wooden bowls of different shapes, a muzzle-loading

shotgun, a few machetes and axes. A lot of drinking vessels, made from the fruit of the calabash tree (Crescentia cujete L.) may also be seen. Wooden spoons are never met with.

The Jicaques collect sarsaparilla and sell deer skins, firewood, pinewood (used for illuminating); they also work as day laborers on the haciendas. Both sexes work on the field. Hunting is the work of the men exclusively, and the women never shoulder a gun, but sometimes accompany the men. Bow and arrow have disappeared and sometimes the lack of powder will reduce them for long periods to a vegetarian diet. They sell fowl, eggs and fat hogs, not having developed a taste for these foodstuffs. The men make matates (net-like baskets) from the fiber of the maguey, while the women make a coarse kind of pottery.

They cultivate to a great extent such Old World plants as bananas, plantains, sugar cane, yams, coffee, citrus fruits and mangoes. Among indigenous food plants may be mentioned maize or Indian corn, of which there are several varieties; further, kidney beans, pumpkins, squashes, cassava, sweet potatoes, malanga (Colocasia esculenta) a plant allied to the taro of the South Sea islands. The pataste or chayote (Chayota edulis); a vine producing pear shaped fruits, covered with small, soft prickles, is also generally found in the neighbourhood of the houses. Chile pepper is used to a very great extent to season food, while the alligator pear and pineapple are common indigenous fruits.

Maize is the staple food. It is kept for a long time by tying it together with the end of the husk and hanging it up to dry inside the house. It is consumed in many different ways, but more frequently in the shape of "we" (tamales). The skin of the maize is removed by boiling same with ashes; it is then ground on the metate with an addition of water. The paste, thus produced, is wrapped in leaves and cooked and will keep for about a week. The mode of preparation is apparently the same as that of the ladinos but the tamales of the latter are far superior to those of the Indians. "Tsets" (tortillas) are also made sometimes. After grinding the corn as stated above a thin round cake is formed, about 5 to 6 inches in diameter, and baked in a round, flat clay griddle over a strong fire. "Pukuy" (pinol) is prepared in the following way: The corn is roasted over a slow fire, and after adding chile pepper it is ground on the metate. It is beaten in cold or hot water before taking. The pinol of the Ladinos differs from that of the Indians in that it contains no chile; it is always sweetened before taking and is appreciated by the average foreigner. "Mats" (pozol) also is prepared from corn. The latter is simply cooked and left to sour, afterwards it is ground on the stone and mixed with water before taking. "Hul" (atol) is prepared from green corn in the following way: The grains are separated from the cob with a knife; after grinding the corn is passed through a sieve, cooked and left to became sour before taking.

Language.

Both sexes generally speak Spanish fluently, and wherever intermarriage with ladinos takes place, the children do not learn the Indian language. The Jicaques are very shy and unwilling to teach other people their language, and as far as I know none of the people living in their villages have ever been able to learn it. I had much difficulty getting the vocabulary given below as the Indians at first would not permit me at all to write down the words, stating that it was impossible to reduce them to writing. With small presents, mostly of tobacco I finally bought their confidence and

at last was allowed to write down words in their language. At some places my efforts to talk to them in their native tongue met with a very cool reception, the Indians telling me that they did not know what I was talking about, and when I insisted they merely walked away and resumed their occupation without paying the least attention to me. Many Spanish words have crept into their language, to express the names of such articles as were unknown to them originally. The vocabulary contained in Membreño's "Hondureñismos" seems to be the only attempt to reduce the language to writing.

Regarding the vocabulary below the following explanation is necessary :

a, e, i, o, u, are pronounced as in Spanish.
ö, as in German Löwe.
ts, as German z in Zeit.
x, as English sh in she.
ch, as in Spanish.
All other letters as in English.

The stress accent is on the last syllable unless otherwise indicated (').

v and f occur in only a few words and are by some people pronounced like b and p respectively.

There is no definite article ; for the indefinite article the cardinal number "pani" (one) is used. It is always placed after the noun.

To express the sex of an animal the word "kokoy" is added for the male and "mumuy" for the female ; "tsikway" (small) is added for the young, thus :

kastre	fowl
kastre kokoy	rooster
kastre mumuy	hen
kastre tsikway	chicken

To express possession the adjective possessive is placed before the noun and the latter is not inflected, for example :

nap tsoyo	my dog
hip tsoyo	your dog
hup tsoyo	his dog

There seem to be some exceptions to this rule, and the following example came to my notice :

nan	my eye
hip hin	your eye
hup hun	his eye

The adjective is invariable and is always placed after the noun.

Numeration is vigesimal ; the Indians generally count only in Spanish for anything over 5.

There are no ordinal numbers.

The verb generally ends the sentence.

There is no conjunction in the Jicaque sentence.

The following vocabulary was taken in different parts of the department of Yoro, but the same language is spoken by the entire Eastern branch. The words enclosed in parenthesis are the corresponding names in the language of the Western branch. From a comparison of the two, it will readily be seen that these languages are mutually intelligible and that they are in reality dialects of the same language. The chief differences seem to consist in the following :

k in the Eastern dialect is substituted for g in the Western dialect.

l (except initial) in the Eastern dialect is substituted for n in the Western dialect.

final p in the Eastern dialect is substituted for k in the Western dialect.

p (except final) in the Eastern dialect is substituted for b in the Western dialect.

The languages of the Paya, Sumu and Mosquito Indians are still spoken on the Mosquito Coast of Honduras; a number of words showing some relation to the Jicaque language, are given below and form only a very small proportion of the vocabulary.

an (kan)	zapote (a fruit tree)
antunun	humming-bird
arpa (arba)	above
askip (askip)	shirt
ats (kat)	blood. Sumu "a"
aua (ko)	fire. Sumu "koh", "kuh"
awa	warm
biknipui	I am hungry
bok	pull out
boteya	bottle. Spanish "botella"
böh (pubö)	rope
brek	much
búa (búa)	jaguar Paya "u", "uha"
búa he (búa he)	puma (lit. red jaguar)
buisis	meat. Sumu "kiwis"
buma	bread-nut tree
dik (dik)	knee
du	calabash
dus	sugar
haipuk	head
ham (ham	axe; also thorn, prickle
hamain	grave
hani	to dream
harek (harek)	bow
hasteok	strong
hau	needle
he (he)	red
hene (hene)	mosquito
hin (wut)	eye
hin druk	blind
hin sisak	tears
hive, hibe	it is raining
hiwe (mon duvera)	winter, rainy season
hop	fresh water crab
hip (hik)	you
hipitsa (hiktsa)	yours
hok (hobi)	bush, forest
horsun	breast
hose	why
hoyóro	kidney
hötsö	sour
hul (tsugu)	atole
humoy (kamuey)	malanga
hup (huk)	he
huputsa (huktsa)	his
hupue (hubue)	iguana
huts (bnt)	opossum
huyu	grass
huwu	water
kafe, kape (kafe)	coffee. Spanish "café"
kaite	sandal. Spanish "caite"
kalsong (kansong)	breeches Sp. "calzón"
kamba	far
kan (kan)	bed
karabas	calabash (from Sp. "calabazo")
kastre (kastre)	fowl; also banana
kat	where
kavyu	horse (from Sp. "cavallo)"
ke (keke)	agouti. Mosquito "kyaki"
kel	chachalaca
kep (kek)	woman
kere (kre)	lean, meagre; also bone
kerep	nephew; also niece
kikway	grandchild
kinkin sois	it is cold
kirik	parrot
kive	here
ko	green corn
kok	guajiniquil (a tree)
kokam	uncle
koko (koko)	coconut. (from Sp. coco)
kokoy	headman, cacique; also male
kol (gon)	stomach
kom (kong)	liver
komasopani	five
komaspö	ten
kont (abrugay)	three
kopoinek	bead
korok (korok)	spider
koroso (tsu)	cohune palm. Spanish corozo
kotokot	rabbit
köal (kön)	cassava, manioc
ködö·ötsö	drunk, intoxicated
kör	skirt
köryu	basket
kötmoy	old
krak	pacaya (small palm)
krátsa	cockroach. Spanish "cucaracha"
kua (kua)	none
kukutsay	daugter
kul	fish
kuyu	ant-eater
kyol	to grind
la	to eat
lakasai (kre)	ant
laksak, loksak (latsak)	day; also sun
lam (dara)	mouth
lans	lemon
lats, laks (lats)	snake
lats he	coral snake (lit. red snake)
lea	name
leka	olla (earthen cooking pot)
lemlem	butterfly
lipyun	to weep
lo	leaf (tree)
lokots	papaya (a fruit)
lotot (prot)	bark (tree), skin, peelings, shell,
lu (lu)	yellow
luak	dew
luluy	soft
lup (uruk)	lips
lupu (lubu)	air; also wind
luru (luru)	navel

lus	sugar ; also sweet
ma (na, momo)	earth, soil, ground
ma hul (na hu, momo hu	hole (in the ground)
maha	to sleep
mak (mak)	ladino (Sp. speaking Honduranean)
mak pe (mak pe)	foreigner (lit. white ladino)
mak te (mak te)	negro (lit. black ladino)
mánte, mande (mande)	john crow (a bird)
mara (maru)	curassow (a bird)
marakang (markang)	white faced monkey
maran (maran)	pig, hog perhaps from Sp. "marrano"
marára	bad, ugly, stingy
mas (namat)	hand
masat	deer. Aztec " mazatl "
maska, masnukup	let us go
máta (mata)	two
mats (tsatbu)	pozol
matsats	pineapple. Sumu " masa "
matuay	a little
maunla	to roast
mentong	neck
mentsyuts	cough
mentsyutska	to cough
mik (mik)	nose
minde (minde)	wild cane
minhak	how are you
mist (mi tu)	cat. Sumu " mistu "; Paya " misto"
mitsul	green corn
modut (komodut)	small lizard
mol (nunfe)	cloud
mongkoy (mongkoy)	matate (net-like basket)
mongkuts	elbow
möna	sweet potato
mukusus (mukusus)	Ladino
mumuy (mumuy)	female; moon ; month
muös	to drink
musk (namut, komusut)	smoke
muts (muin)	yam
mutsahan	basket
mutsits (mitsit)	cutlass, machete
myolko	to boil
nahats	there, yonder
nahas	heart
nam (namfe)	peccary
namap	aunt
namay (namay)	mother. Sumu " nana, nanang"
nap (nak)	I
napatsa (nantsa)	mine
napey	brother-in-law
nasetya	late
nasum	good bye
natam	brother
nataway	son
natsom	wife
nayam	father-in-law
nen (nen)	hill, mountain
netseska	to sing
nop (duk)	maize
notsots (notsot)	fly (insect)
nu (nu)	pumpkin, squash
nurö	maguey (a plant)
nyapin	close
on	bitter
ouh (koh)	sugar cane. Paya " uh "
oyo (koyo)	pine. Paya " aro "
ök	good, kind, beautiful
pa	dry
pakas	to hear
pani	one
papay (ba, babay)	father. Sumu " papang "
pasa (patsa)	macaw
pats (bat)	ear
pe (pe)	white; also stone in Sumu white is pi, pihni
pe salakor	metate
pe mos	metate pestle
pe hul (pe hu)	cave
pehey (pue)	egg
pel (pen)	flee ; also shoulder
pens	feather
pep (pet)	nail (finger), claw
perang (berang)	tongue
peretsey (tsey)	worm
petel (peten)	wasp
pirey	bamboo
pitsam	mother-in-law
piye	excrement
pokue (pindara)	striped
ponik	lard, fat, grease
popoy (pumbuy)	lungs
potop	deaf
porok	skin, hide
porosos	sour-sop (a fruit)
pots	jinicuite (a tree)
potsik	handle (as of an axe)
poyom (poyom)	paca (a quadruped)
poyos (bihuk)	hawk
pö (pubu)	ashes
pöl (tsibrak)	star
pöröl	cloth
pöxtumo	dark
pratang (prang)	plantain. Sp. " platano ". Paya " prata "
puel	arm
puepe	spleen, milt
puiste	night
pukuy (puguy)	pinol
pune (pöne)	big, large
puös (puös)	deer

pusus	feather
puts	to spit
puya (pia)	tobacco
puyawa	it is warm
sai, savya (sai savya)	peccary
san	how
sapat (tsombit)	shoe
sar	to toast
sek	chin
sepep	zanate (a bird)
sin	to plant, sow
solol (tsoron)	oak
solsis	sky
sombrero (apit)	hat. Sp. " sombrero "
songroy	gadfly
söol	guava
supap	to tie
sus (tsitsuk)	sand
suy (dey)	rubber
suyu (tsiau)	black faced monkey
tapúa	strings used by the diviner
tampin	yesterday
tawana	late
te (te)	black
tek (tek)	leg
tem (teng)	boa (a snake)
tembe	side (of body)
temel (momba)	money
temel pe	silver (lit. white money)
temel he	gold (lit. yellow money)
tenkwit (pisik)	toucan (a bird)
tepe	dead
tepuy	to die
tera	to bite
til (til)	tapir. Mosquito " tilba "
tol, tor (tol, tor)	Jicaque
tomah	to rot
tomakas	young
torö	turkey
trabaholey	work. Sp. " trabajo "
trum	sore, ulcer
tuhul	calabash
tul	shotgun
tunim (tring)	cotton
tupue	to burn
tut (tut)	louse ; also saliva
tsa	silkgrass (a plant)
tsals, tsars (tsansa)	sarsaparilla
tsarin (tsarin)	salt
tsax	honey. Paya " ase "
tsaxpone	bee
tse (tse)	pate (vine used to poison fish)
tseb	scorpion
tsek (tsetsek)	coal
tsekene	to run
tsekterem (tsektereng)	woodpecker
tséle (tsere)	chile pepper
tseme (tseme)	horn ; also comb
tsemea (tsima)	bow
tsenam pani	twenty
tsenam máta	forty
tsets (bi)	tortilla
tsii (tsatse)	devil, evil spirit
tsikway (kutsway)	small
tsil (tsi)	hair (of body); also root (tree)
tsinam	converse, talk
tsinya (tsinya)	enemy
tsinay	pinuela (a plant)
tsing (tsing)	bean. Sumu " sinak ", Mosquito " snik "
tsip (ham)	thorn, prickle. Paya " siki "
tsipuay	sister
tsir, tsin (tsin)	hair (of head)
tsitsim	nerve, muscle
tsit (tsit)	alligator pear. Sumu and Mosquito " sikya "
tsiv	nance (a fruit)
tsive	brain
tsoix	cold
tsok (tsok)	tail
tsol (tsotson)	coati (a quadruped)
tsom	foot
tsoro (tsoro)	shade, shadow
tsoropa (tsoroma	armpit
tsots (tsots)	owl ; also female breast
tsoyo	dog. Sumu " sulo "
tsö (tsö)	water; river, creek. Paya " aso "
tsö (karende)	rum
tsö nive	I am thirsty
tsöo oy	tinaja (earthen water container)
tsöbay	fowl
tsöp	devil, evil spirit
tsu (tsu)	blue, green
tsu (gutsu)	squirrel. Sumu " buska "; Mosquito " butsung "
tsuey (tsugoy)	woodlouse
tsul (tsun)	intestines
tsumpue (tsumbue)	tick
tsun	sick
tsungkwoy (tsungoy)	soursop (a fruit)
tsunu	to get sick
tsurutsut (hamu)	bat
tsuts	bijagua (plant with big leaves)
uruk (urup)	yellow-tail (a bird)
ururu	raccoon
uyus	urine
veapay (tsikin duvera)	summer, dry season
wa (wa)	house, habitation
wal (wang)	arnotto (a dye). Sumu " awal "
wamuwas	to enter
warekesa	forehead
wayum	husband
we (bi)	tamal
wing (bi)	frog ; toad

wintsir	rib
wix (bit)	tooth
wöt (wöt)	firewood
wurax	fruit
yay	to-morrow
yakats	to-day
yam	wax
yats	cedar. Mosquito "yalam"
yo (yo)	tree
yomal	plain, level
yom (yom)	man
yuku (yugu)	coyol (a palm)
yukuts (yukuts)	armadillo
yurupana (yurubana)	four
yus (yus)	wild turkey
yuts	alligator